

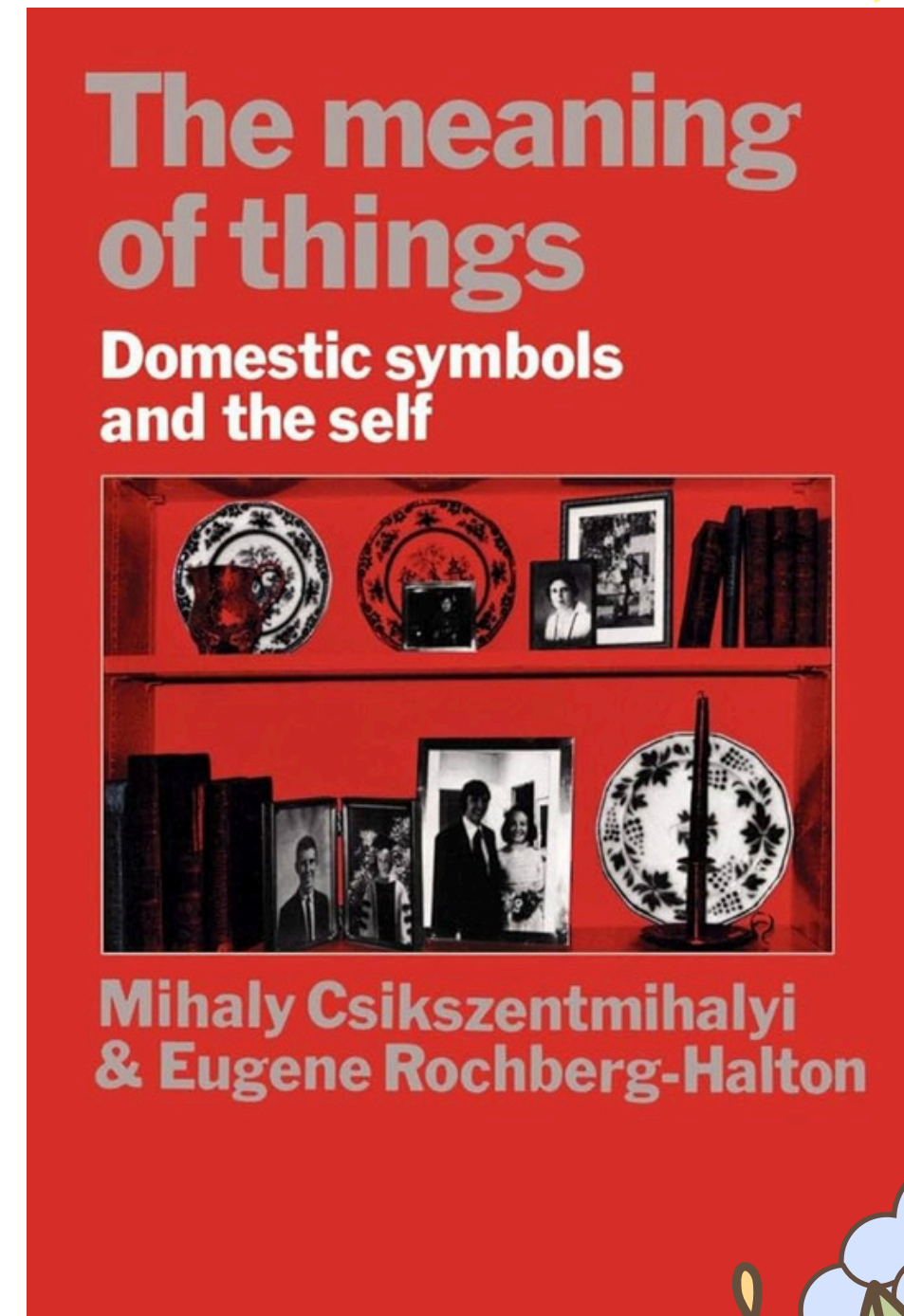


DESIGN & SELF

by Natwara Somboonsub



THE MEANING OF
THINGS: DOMESTIC
SYMBOLS AND THE SELF
BY MIHALY
CSIKSZENTMIHALYI &
EUGENE ROCHBERG-
HALTON (C&R)





Redefine before using it.

PEOPLE

persons are not only aware of their own existence but can assume control of that existence, directing it toward certain purposes

THINGS

thing got viewed as any bit of information that has a recognizable identity in consciousness, a pattern that has enough coherence, or internal order, to evoke a consistent image or label.





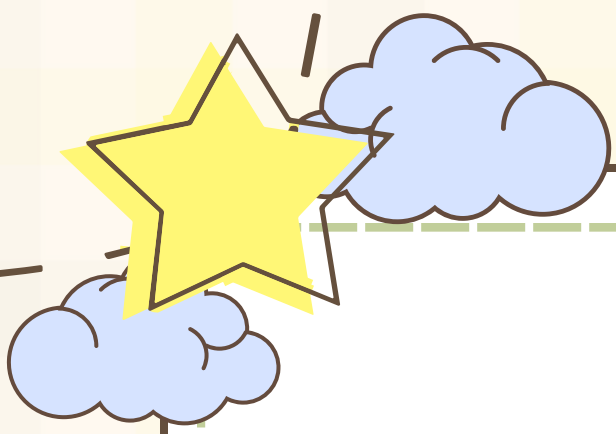
THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN PEOPLE AND THINGS

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- **Things contribute to the cultivation of the self** when they help create order in consciousness at the levels of the person, community, and patterns of natural order.
 - objects are so intimately related to the self
 - An object that, when attended to, inhibits the pursuit of goals at any of these levels is a hindrance to the development of the self
 - "Guns don't kill people, people do." (The neutrality of the object is assumed; people's intentions will be carried out independently of the things they use.)
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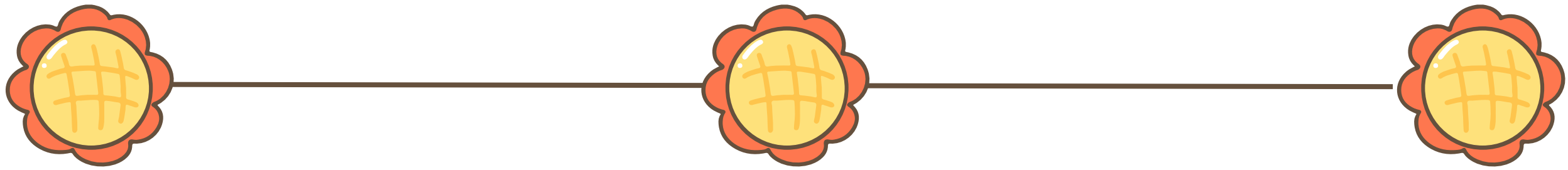


PEOPLE AND THINGS

- **Things matter to the self. Things are expressive themselves.**
 - The things with which people interact are **not simply tools for survival.** Things embody goals, make skills manifest, and **shape the identities of their users.**
 - Social scientists tend to look for the understanding of human life in the internal psychic processes of the individual or in the patterns of relationship between people; **rarely do they consider the role of material objects.**
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PEOPLE AND THINGS



- **Descartes**, who grounded knowledge within the unity of the cogito, the subjective self-awareness.
 - **"I think, therefore I am."**
The self is the subject of thought or **self-awareness**, and **its existence** ("therefore I am")
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- self-awareness as a process of self-control rather than as a static moment of original apperception.
- Cartesian influence was to seek the meaning of the self, or indeed of any inquiry, in an absolute origin or beginning, a "cardinal conception."

- A Cartesian approach consists of peeling off the allegedly false persona or mask of the self to attain the "real me" (or cogito) inside.
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•Comparison Between Descartes (Rationalism) and C&R (Revisionism):

Descartes	C&R
"Self" IS the <i>Beginning</i> (Cogito or the "Real Me" Inside or the Absolute Origin).	"Self" IS the <i>Outcome</i> (through Critical Reflection of Things or <i>Cultivation</i>).
The Cartesian Approach = Peeling off the Allegedly False Persona or Mask of the Self to Attain the "Real Me"	C&R Approach = Cultivation as a Self-Corrective Process, in Which Some Goals Are Refined or Given Expressions and the Others Are Rejected





CULTIVATION

- **Cultivation is a psychic activity that is only possible because humans are able to focus their attention selectively in the pursuit of goals.**
 - psychic energy = attention is the medium through which intentional acts can be accomplished
 - Psychic activity consists of **intentions that direct the attention through which information is selected and processed in consciousness.**
 - We shall view the **self in a context of cultivation** (Rochberg-Halton, 1979a,b), a process of interpretation and self-control motivated by goals rather than by origins.
 - If **cultivation is a self-corrective process**, in which some goals are refined or given expression, and others are rejected, then the self should be the culmination of cultivation itself.
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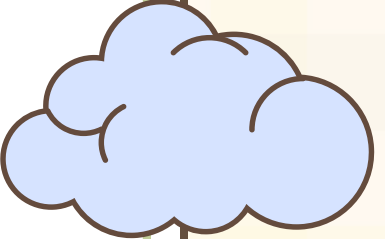


PSYCHIC ACTIVITY

- psychic activity is ultimately grounded in the underlying mechanistic forces of the unconscious. Cultivation only serves to repress and sublimate the original impulses that are beyond the process of representation. In contrast, we assume that the meaning of psychic activity is to be found in the intentions that one forms as a result of cultivation.
 - The actualization of intentions is dependent on the available psychic energy, or attention. Any intentional act requires attention
 - **Only by concentrating attention can we "make things happen."**
 - attention is a finite resource
 - It **requires effort to concentrate**, that is, to keep the same information in focus for any length of time
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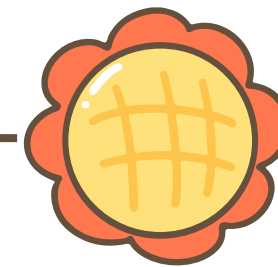
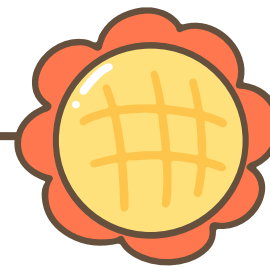
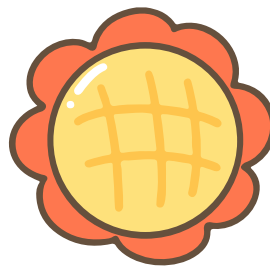


SOCIAL SYSTEM

-  Among **the patterns of ordered information that depend on attention for their existence** are what we usually call social systems.
 -  A **social system** is a **predictable pattern of interaction among persons made possible by shared structures of attention.**
 -  Social systems involving more than two people also rely on the same pool of limited attention for their survival.
 -  The relationship between social systems and personal consciousness, each structuring and being structured by the other, is so delicate as to appear circular
 -  social systems survive by structuring the attention of individuals or socialization
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PERSONHOOD



- by the **cultivation of goals through limited attention, individuals become persons**
- When someone invests psychic energy in an object - a thing, another person, or an idea - that object becomes "**charged**" with the energy of the agent.
- **"Personhood" = The Ability to Advocate One's Psychic Energy Freely**

- lost invested energy can turn into a gain if as a result of the investment the agent achieves a goal he or she has set for his or herself. Accomplishing a goal provides positive feedback to the self and strengthens it in allowing the self to grow.

- **Personhood depends on the ability to allocate one's psychic energy freely.** An individual cannot become a person if he or she is unable to cultivate his or her goals, and therefore the shape that the self will take.
 - **"Selfhood" = How is "self" shaped by environments and ordinary physical things**
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ENERGY

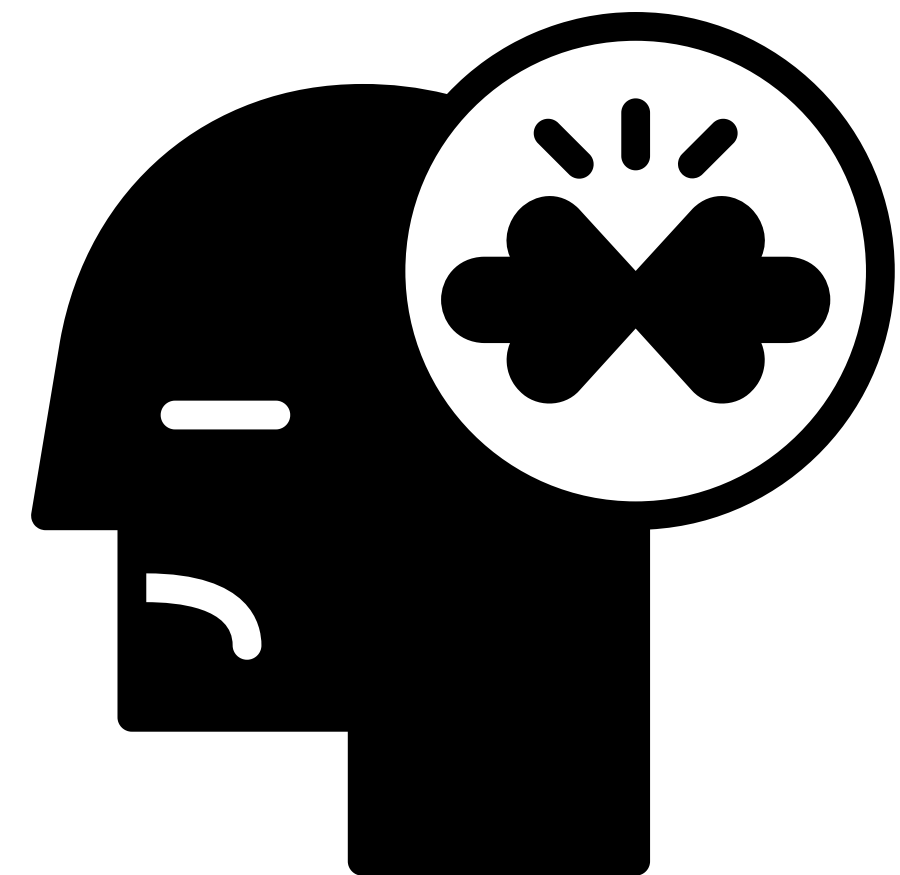
- The simplest tasks of information processing, of attention allocation, become problematic when one is unable to dispose of his or her psychic energy freely (McGhie and Chapman, 1961; Freedman, 1974; Shield et al., 1974)

- The optimal state of experience for the individual is one in which intentions are not in conflict with each other. In this state of inner harmony people can freely choose to invest their psychic energy in goals that are congruent with the rest of their intentions.
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INNER CONFLICT

- The **opposite of psychic order is inner conflict** - the desire to do incompatible things
- Psychic energy is focused on conflicting intentions. This reduces the effectiveness of psychic activity, for the two goals interfere with each other.

- experiences are anxiety, frustration, alienation, or boredom, all referring to temporary impairments of psychic activity.
- The **ability to invest psychic energy freely is the prerequisite toward achieving self-control.**





SUM OF PERSON

- the fullest development of personhood involves a free ordering of psychic energy at the level of the individual
 - **The person who is able to cultivate his or her own desires**, the goals of the community, and the laws of nature, and is able to reconcile these patterns, succeeds in establishing a temporary structure of order out of potential randomness. This is the creation of cosmos out of chaos and the ultimate touchstone of what is ordinarily called mental health, or **self-actualization**.
 - **Cultivation refers to the process of investing psychic energy so that one becomes conscious of the goals operating within oneself**
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THE NATURE OF THINGS

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- view a **thing** as any bit of **information that has a recognizable identity in consciousness, a pattern that has enough coherence, or internal order, to evoke a consistent image or label.**
 - **Such a unit of information** might be called a **sign**
 - a consistent image or label. Such a unit of information might be called a sign, to borrow a term from semiotic. In this perspective a symbol is only one kind of sign - a sign defined as the representation of some object (a quality, physical thing, or idea) to some other interpreting sign
 - **objects have the peculiar character of objectivity, that is, they tend to evoke similar responses from the same person over time and from different people.**
 - **Man-made things = objects that were shaped by human intentionally. dependent on intention for their existence**
 - **the things that surround us are inseparable from who we are.**
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HANNAH ARENDT



- The Human Condition (1958)
 - Stabilizing Identity = We make order out of chaos (Shapeless Self) in 3 arenas (Mind/Man, Body/Nature)
 - Things or objects surrounding us are part of who we are
 - the development of human-kind to be able to create one's world is in many ways unique
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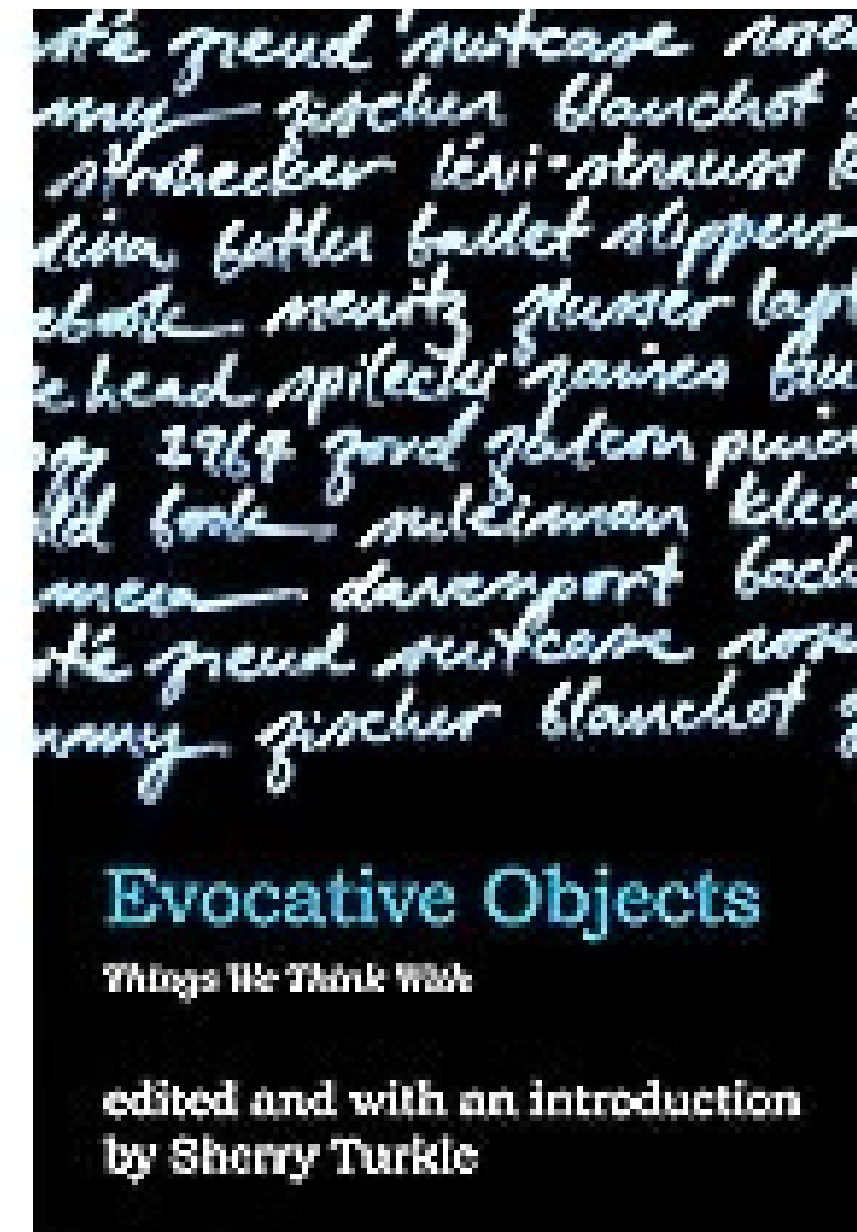


OBJECT

- **objects are so intimately related to the self**
 - Things contribute to the cultivation of the self when they help create order in consciousness at the levels of the person
 - **Material environment that surrounds us is rarely neutral**; it either helps the forces of chaos that make life random and disorganized or it helps to give purpose and direction to one's life
 - the characteristic of objects is grounded in their physical structure so that an artifact from an ancient people can still convey an image of the ideas of that culture even though there may be no record of how those people spoke or what they believed
 - Things shape our personalities. Things change our lives
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SHERRY TURKLE: EVOCATIVE OBJECTS: THINGS WE THINK WITH (2007)





EVOCATIVE OBJECT

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- **Subjective Technology:** Providing an Emotional Depth to Physical Things
 - **Instrumental Technology:** Serving as an Effective Tool, Aid, or Utility for Human Beings
 - the ultimate expression of Subjective Technology. Turkle explains that objects become evocative when it transcends the bounds of instrumental purpose. They are no longer just tools but thing we think with. **objects become emotional objects when they carry powerful personal and symbolic meanings.** they might trigger memories, help people process complex emotions, or become a tangible piece of your personal history and identity
 - In conclusion, Turkle's classification encourages us understand the journey object can take from being a common tool to becoming a profound part of our psychological lives. Evocative objects are objects that have traveled deep into the inner feelings
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TECHNOLOGY

Instrumental Technology: This is about what technology does for us. It views objects as neutral tools designed for a specific function or utility. Think of a hammer, a calculator, or a word processor in its most basic sense. Its value lies in its practical application.

Subjective Technology: examining the psychological impact of technology on our lives; and exploring how technology shapes our identities, emotions, and thoughts, becoming an integral part of our inner selves.

Instrumental Technology	Subjective Technology
What a tech can DO FOR US?	What a tech can DO TO US?
Neutral Physical Things NOT Important to "Self"	Physical Things HELP Constituting "Self"





SUM

- Both C&R and Turkle discuss “designs” in terms of deep psychological questions, pointing to the contexts of “self.” The “self” is contextualized in multiple ways such as in temporal or spatial dimensions. The self-identification is a discursive process, happening in time and space
 - C&R think Design SHOULD expand the horizon of possibilities, by stimulating actions to change the world or providing solutions to real-world problems
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THANK YOU